



Pitch spat: India head coach Gautam Gambhir was involved in a confrontation with Lee Fortis, Surrey's head of groundstaff, during training ahead of the fifth and final Test at The Oval. REUTERS

CRICKET, CONFLICT AND CATHARSIS: WHAT THE OVAL OFFERED

Tempers, tributes, and Test glory: A packed final week at The Oval ends with India's epic comeback.

Shayan Acharya
shayan.acharya@thehindu.co.in

Sitting on the staircase of the Micky Stewart Pavilion, Lee Fortis had a wry smile. The final Test was still two days away, but the Oval curator had already made headlines after a spat with India head coach Gautam Gambhir. As the touring media and English press queued outside his small cabin, Fortis appeared unfazed. Wiping his face with his sweatshirt, he muttered, "You all saw what happened..."

Pressed further, Fortis — often described as a "tough nut" by the English press — called Gambhir a "tetchy guy". But as many struggled with his accent, headlines quickly misquoted him, suggesting he'd called the India coach a "touchy guy".

To clarify, Fortis rang up The Diary and a scribe from a national wire agency — "curious guys", he called them. "T-e-t-c-h-y," he spelt out. "You saw who started it."

While the BCCI and ECB scrambled

to downplay the matter, Fortis made it clear he wouldn't forget. "I never forget. I always remember," he said rhythmically, before hurrying off to cover the square as clouds loomed overhead.

Over the next five days, Fortis let his work speak. Named ECB's best curator several times, he produced what many agreed was the finest wicket of the series. A touch of green early on pleased the quicks, while the surface eased out later, aiding